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spirit of india special ■

local 'dominant caste', have been substituted by a new generation of politicians, who are often poorly educated, provincial and come from lower-middle class backgrounds, and often also from lower/backward castes. New regional parties which draw their support from marginalised groups have been formed (such as the Bahujan Samaj Party). Their main demand became 'social justice' and in their political propaganda 'democracy' was (and is) often thought of in narrow terms relating to caste/community socio-economic uplift.

These new vernacular political leaders often tend to pitch their message and policies to, and hence draw support from, their own caste/communities rather than trying to appeal across castes and beyond their regions. Indeed, the numerical size of lower caste groups in particular states (for instance, the Chamars in Uttar Pradesh, the Yadavs in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar and the Jats of Rajasthan and Haryana) makes this strategy particularly effective. In recent years, party leaders have not only focused on making appeals to their own communities, but have directly and indirectly shaped the agenda of their caste associations in a wider process of community formation.

In recent years, caste associations, which are a key area for provincial politicians to draw support, used a variety of cultural resources such as myths of origin and heroic traditions to refashion their communities and reconfigure who belongs to their community. They often take this opportunity to redefine kinship relations by playing down internal caste hierarchies and cultural differences and encouraging marriage between the different subdivisions of the same caste. In doing so, they transformed their diversified

communities into united and more numerous blocs, which then have become more competitive in the democratic arena. This is part of an on-going historical process but it has certainly been revamped and re-energised in the last decade. Colonial and post-colonial governance and the institutions of representative democracy opened up an arena for all Indians to re-write their

UNLESS THE BSP GOVERNMENT is in power both at the Centre and Uttar Pradesh, the country and the state will not progress.

MAYAWATI,
UTTAR PRADESH
CHIEF MINISTER

This provides the basis for new forms of political competition. And it is precisely as 'horizontal' groups that they have been mobilised by regional political parties. It represents a shift from the mobilisation techniques used by the Congress during the first decades of rule.

During the 1950s and 1960s, the Congress transformed patron-client relations between so-called 'dominant castes' and other castes into a votebank through 'vertical mobilisation'. In doing so the party put together coalitions of upper and lower castes. By the 1970s, however, the experience of competitive electoral politics, and the impact of education, reserved jobs and land reforms, weakened local structures of dominance, and this opened up political spaces for traditionally marginalised (both economically and ritually) castes and communities.

As people gradually stopped to vote along vertical lines of mobilisation, politicians began to mobilise backward and lower castes horizontally. By the early 1990s, the Indian political system had moved from a one-dominant party system to a genuine competitive multi-party system. The opening up of democracy contributed towards different patterns of authority and to the emergence of a new class of politician from humble social backgrounds. The partymen of the Congress, who often belonged to the

Power PLAY

2000 The NDA, led by the BJP's Atal Bihari Vajpayee, becomes the first non-Congress government to complete its term. It is a coalition backed by a cluster of regional parties.



2004 The Congress emerges as the single largest party, forms the UPA Government under Manmohan Singh. But with only 151 seats, it is constantly bullied by regional allies.

2009 During the vote of confidence over the nuclear deal, the Left and other parties try to bring down the UPA Government by cobbling together a non-BJP, non-Congress block. The Samajwadi Party comes to the Congress's rescue and saves the UPA.

2009 With 207 MPs, the Congress gets the upper hand over its allies; the UPA comes to power again at the Centre, but without old faithful RJD.